

Sunburn

IST Open-Source Guideline Content | Mixed · Version Year 2026 · Protocol ID AlgorithmID 1010 (oscg-sunburn)

Definition

Damage to the skin caused by too much sun exposure. Usually resolves within about a week and can be managed independently at home, but severe cases can progress to heat exhaustion or heatstroke.

Severity / Key Points

- Affected skin may feel hot, sore, or painful, and typically flakes or peels a few days after the sunburn occurs.
- Fair skin usually reddens or turns pink; darker skin tones may show minimal colour change.
- Severe sunburn can blister.
- Getting sunburnt increases the risk of skin cancer.

Initial Assessment Questions

Category	Question	Choices
Exposure	How much sun exposure, and which areas are affected?	Free text
Blistering	Is the skin blistered?	Yes / No
Temperature	Has a temperature been measured? If so, what was it?	Numeric / free text

Triage Assessment Questions and Dispositions

#	Question	Disposition
1	Is there confusion, fainting, a very high temperature with no sweating, or a rapid heartbeat suggesting heatstroke rather than simple sunburn?	Call Emergency Services Now (LevelID 100)
2	Is the skin blistered or swollen, is the temperature very high or does the caller feel hot, cold, or shivery, does the caller feel very tired, dizzy, or sick, is there a headache or muscle cramps, or is the patient a baby or young child?	See Urgent Care Today (LevelID 70)
3	Is this mild-to-moderate sunburn without blistering or the features above?	Home Care (LevelID 15)

Care Advice

Emergency heat-illness precautions — Move to a cool place, cool the skin, and arrange emergency transport immediately. Call Back If: worsening confusion, loss of consciousness.

Urgent sunburn review — Cool the skin, stay hydrated, and arrange same-day medical review, especially for blistering or a young child. Call Back If: fever worsens, increasing dizziness.

Home care for sunburn — Get out of the sun, cool the skin with a cool shower or damp towels, apply aftersun or unperfumed moisturiser, stay hydrated, and take paracetamol or ibuprofen as needed. Avoid alcohol and further sun exposure. Call Back If: blistering develops, or fever, dizziness, or feeling very unwell develops.

Background

See Severity / Key Points above. Expert reviewer: NHS.UK clinical editorial review (source publisher).

First Aid

- Get out of the sun immediately.
- Cool the skin using a cool shower, bath, or damp towels.
- Apply aftersun cream or unperfumed moisturiser.
- Stay hydrated; avoid alcohol.
- Take paracetamol or ibuprofen as directed if needed.
- Avoid petroleum jelly, ice packs, scratching, removing peeling skin, or popping blisters.

References

1. NHS.UK. "Sunburn." <https://www.nhs.uk/conditions/sunburn/> (page last reviewed 24 November 2025).
2. NHS.UK. "Heat exhaustion and heatstroke." <https://www.nhs.uk/conditions/heat-exhaustion-heatstroke/> (page last reviewed 28 May 2026, next review 28 May 2029).

Search Words

SUNBURN, SUNBURNED, SUN BURN, TOO MUCH SUN, SUN EXPOSURE, HEAT EXHAUSTION

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